

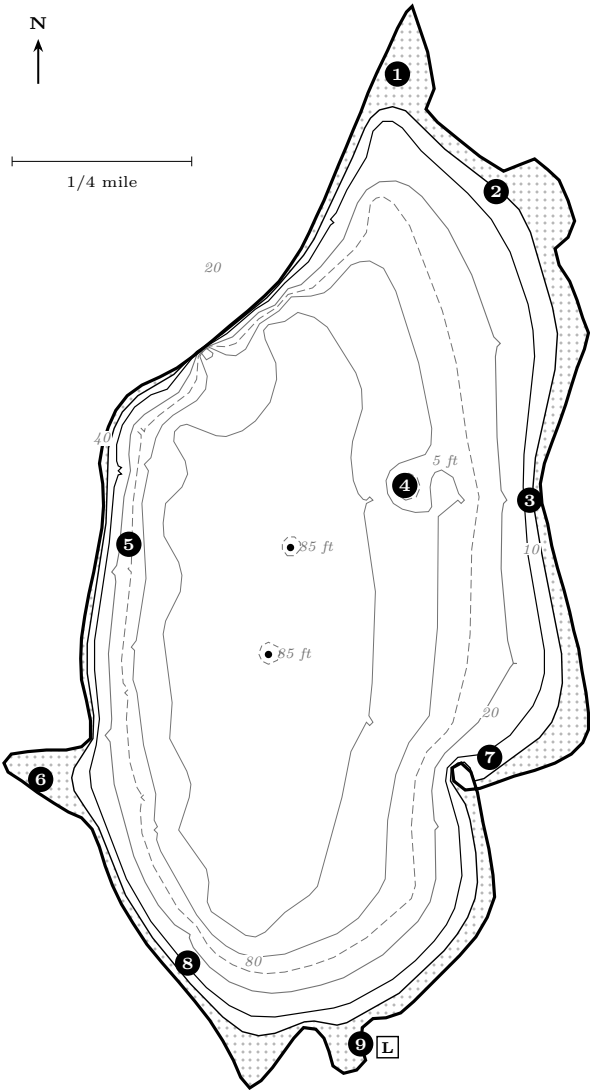
Pine Lake

Town of Merton & Village of Chenequa

Waukesha County, Wisconsin — 711 acres, 85 ft maximum depth

Pine Lake is deep, cold and startlingly clear, and almost everything that makes it hard to fish follows from those three facts. Ninety per cent of the bottom is gravel. The water clears far enough that weeds grow past 15 ft, that fish see your line, and that the best bites come at the edges of the day. It stratifies hard by early summer into a warm upper layer and a cold, oxygenated basin below, and it holds cisco — an open-water forage fish — which means the biggest predators in this lake spend much of the summer suspended over 60 ft of water rather than sitting on the weed edge where you would like them to be.

Surface	711 acres (698 acres on the 1955 survey); 6.7 miles of shoreline
Depth	85 ft maximum, 39 ft mean — one of the deepest lakes in the county
Bottom	Gravel 90%, muck 5%, sand 5%. Hard bottom nearly everywhere
Clarity	Very clear. Expect weed growth to 15–20 ft and spooky fish in calm sun
Fish	Largemouth and smallmouth bass (common), panfish, northern pike, walleye (stocked as large fingerlings in alternate years), cisco
Access	One public launch, Village of Chenequa. 6 a.m.–10 p.m., except the general fishing opener when it opens 4 a.m.–midnight. Launch fees apply (roughly \$8–\$15 by boat length); verify current hours and fees



Depth in feet. Schematic — not for navigation. Redrawn from the Wisconsin Conservation Department lake survey of 6 June 1955 (WBIC 779200), published by the Wisconsin DNR as a public document. Contours are reconstructed from that survey's soundings and are generalized.

under 5 ft shoreline 5 & 10 ft 20 ft 30 ft 40 & 60 ft 80 ft ④ spot L public launch

The nine spots, by season

Depths below are where the fish are, not where the spot is. Everything on this lake runs deeper than you expect because the water is so clear.

#	Spot	When & what	How
1	North arm shallows	Apr–early Jun: bluegill, pumpkinseed, largemouth, early pike. Nov–Mar: panfish under ice.	First water in the lake to warm. Fish 3–8 ft over emerging weed. Slip bobber and a small leech or half a crawler; a weightless wacky-rigged worm for bass.
2	North-east shoreline break	May–Jun smallmouth; Sep–Nov walleye and pike.	A scalloped shore with points and pockets and a fast drop. Work the points with a jig-and-minnow along the 12–20 ft line; cast tubes to the rock in spring.
3	East wall	Jul–Sep smallmouth, walleye, suspended fish.	The steepest drop in the lake — 20 ft is a short cast from shore. Drop-shot or a slow lindy rig down the 25–40 ft face. Best at first and last light.
4	Mid-lake bar	Jun–Oct , the whole cast: smallmouth, walleye, crappie, big pike.	A hard 5 ft crest surrounded by 60 ft. The single best piece of structure here. Start on top at dawn, then follow the fish down the sides to 18–30 ft as the sun climbs. Jig-and-minnow, drop-shot, or a deep crankbait on the edge.
5	West shelf	May–Sep largemouth and bluegill; Oct pike.	The gentlest slope in the lake, with the deepest weed growth. Fish the outside weed edge at 12–18 ft. Texas-rigged plastic through the weeds, slip bobber on the edge.
6	West bay	Late May–Jun bluegill and pumpkinseed on beds; largemouth all summer. Jan–Feb panfish.	Shallow, protected and weedy — the classic spawning bay. Small hook, small bait, light line, and stay back from the beds. Prime water to put a child on fish.
7	South-east bay	Apr–May crappie and bluegill; Jun–Aug largemouth.	A small round pocket that warms early and holds spring fish before the main lake turns on. Slip bobber over 6–12 ft.
8	South-west taper	Sep–Nov walleye and pike; Jun–Aug smallmouth deep.	Deep water swings close to the bank here. Troll or drift the 20–35 ft break with a lindy rig and a big minnow in fall.
9	Outlet bay	Apr–May and Oct–Nov pike; panfish in summer.	Shallow, weedy, with some current. Pike stage here early and again in fall. Big sucker on a quick-strike rig under a float, or a spinnerbait over the weed tops.

Reading the year

Ice-out–April	Everything is shallow and everything is in the bays. Spots 1, 6, 7, 9. Water under 50 °F: slow down, use bait.
May–June	Spawn moves through in order — pike first, then walleye, then bass, then panfish last on the beds. Fish stay shallow. Bass season opens the first Saturday in May; check the current dates.
July–August	The lake stratifies. Panfish and largemouth hold the deep weed edge (spots 5, 6); smallmouth, walleye and big pike go to the bar and the east wall (3, 4) or suspend over the basin chasing cisco.
September–October	Turnover scatters fish for a week or two, then the best fishing of the year begins. Big fish move up onto structure and eat hard. Spots 2, 4, 8.
November–ice	Deep and slow. The bar and the east wall hold fish into December.
Ice season	Panfish in the bays (1, 6); pike on tip-ups over the weed edges. <i>Walleye, bass and pike close 7 March; panfish stay open.</i>

CHECK THE REGULATIONS BEFORE EVERY TRIP

The 2026–27 rules for this water are: largemouth and smallmouth bass 14in minimum, 5 per day, 2 May–7 March, catch-and-release the rest of the year; walleye 18in minimum, 3 per day; northern pike 26in minimum, 2 per day; muskellunge 40in minimum, 1 per day, open water only through 31 December; panfish 25 per day; cisco and whitefish 10 per day. **These change.** The Wisconsin DNR publishes the current rules for this exact water body, and only that publication is authoritative.

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